

A FRAMEWORK IN CHAPTERS

Chapter Fourteen

Amatonormativity

*The compulsory couple-form ·
what it enforces on the uncoupled*

Amatonormativity is the compulsory couple-form — the assumption that everyone desires and should pursue a romantic partnership, and that such a partnership is the highest form of human connection. This chapter runs it through the five domains — from the family event to the dating app to the slow death of the single person whose social network collapses as friends pair off.

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CHAPTER 14 OF AN ONGOING FRAMEWORK

Amatonormativity

Amatonormativity is the thirteenth Fundamental Matrix. It is the compulsory couple-form — the assumption that everyone desires and should pursue a romantic partnership, and that such a partnership is the highest form of human connection. The term was coined by the philosopher Elizabeth Brake in *Minimizing Marriage* (2011) to name the discrimination faced by the single, the aromantic, and the non-coupled.

Amatonormativity overlaps with Cisheteropatriarchy (Chapter 5, which enforces the heterosexual couple-form with gendered roles) and with Kinship Normativity (Chapter 4, which enforces blood and marriage family). But the three matrices are not the same. Cisheteropatriarchy ranks by gender and sexuality. Kinship Normativity ranks by blood and marriage. Amatonormativity ranks by the couple-form itself. The framework separates them so that each logic can be studied and dismantled on its own terms.

A note on scope. The framework's outline is explicit: gendered role expectations within couples belong to Cisheteropatriarchy and are excluded from this analysis. Amatonormativity is about what the couple-form enforces on and extracts from anyone who is single, aromantic, or not properly coupled — regardless of the gender of the couple or the roles within it.

A note on method. The Interpersonal, Disciplinary, and Structural sections take the naive approach. The Hegemonic Domain section is where Canon and Practice enter the picture. A critical note: Amatonormativity is ascended but does **not** produce Stratification, so Internalised Domination is omitted entirely from the Hegemonic Domain.

READING NOTE

Same convention as Chapters 1 through 13. Every paragraph is written to be tweetable. Where you see literal blanks (____), the framework is asking you to write yourself into it. This chapter's blanks may be uncomfortable: every Nigerian has been asked 'when are you getting married?' and many have asked it of others. The framework asks you to see that question as enforcement, not curiosity.

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SECTION 1

1. Definition: What Amatonormativity Extracts, Enforces, and Removes

Amatonormativity is the compulsory couple-form. The term was coined by Elizabeth Brake in *Minimizing Marriage* (2011) to describe ‘the widespread assumption that everyone is better off in an exclusive, romantic, long-term coupled relationship, and that everyone is seeking such a relationship.’ The assumption is so deep that most people have never considered an alternative.

bell hooks, in *All About Love* (2000) and *Communion* (2002), showed how the romantic couple-form has colonised the concept of love itself, reducing love to romantic love and erasing the love of friendship, community, and self. Adrienne Rich’s ‘Compulsory Heterosexuality’ (1980) overlapped with but was distinct from Amatonormativity: Rich showed that heterosexuality is compulsory, while Brake showed that the couple-form itself is compulsory, regardless of the gender of the couple.

Bella DePaulo’s *Singled Out* (2006) documented the systematic discrimination against singles in housing, taxation, insurance, and social life. Lauren Berlant’s *Cruel Optimism* (2011) showed how the attachment to the couple-form fantasy produces suffering rather than fulfilment — the ‘cruel optimism’ of a promise that never delivers. Eva Illouz’s *The End of Love* (2019) traced how emotional capitalism has commodified the couple-form through dating apps, wedding industries, and the romantic consumer economy.

Zygmunt Bauman’s *Liquid Love* (2003) showed how the couple-form has become fragile under modernity, producing anxiety rather than security. Esther Perel’s *Mating in Captivity* (2006) documented the monocentrism of the couple — the assumption that one person can and should fulfil all emotional, sexual, and domestic needs. Jack Halberstam’s *The Queer Art of Failure* (2011) pointed toward alternative life forms that do not centre the couple.

1.1 What Amatonormativity Extracts

Amatonormativity extracts five things. First, **the single person’s deference to the coupled**: the social expectation that the single person will accommodate the couple’s schedule, the couple’s preferences, and the couple’s needs, because the couple’s relationship is treated as more important than the single person’s friendships or other connections.

Second, **the single person’s stability**: the single person must navigate institutions designed for couples — joint tenancy, joint tax, spousal benefits, hospital visitation — paying the ‘singles tax’ of higher per-person costs and fewer legal protections. Third, **the single person’s legitimacy**: the single person must justify their single status at every family event, every social gathering, and every professional encounter.

Fourth, **the aromantic person's self-acceptance**: the aromantic person — the person who does not experience romantic attraction — is told their orientation is a deficit, a phase, or a disorder. The extraction transfers the aromantic person's self-acceptance to the amatonormative standard. Fifth, **the non-coupled person's social standing**: the non-coupled person is treated as incomplete, as waiting, as not yet arrived at full adulthood.

1.2 What Amatonormativity Enforces

Amatonormativity enforces four standards. First, the **couple-form as the highest relationship**: the assumption that the romantic partnership is the most important relationship a person can have, more important than friendship, family of origin, or community. The couple ranks above every other bond.

Second, the **single as temporary**: the assumption that the single person is in a transitional state, between coupled relationships or heading toward one. The single is not a permanent identity but a waiting room. Third, the **aromantic as broken**: the assumption that the person who does not experience romantic attraction is deficient, in need of repair, or has not yet 'found the right person.'

Fourth, the **dating culture as mandatory**: the assumption that every adult should be actively seeking a romantic partner through the dating infrastructure — the dating app, the matchmaking, the setup, the 'putting yourself out there.' The person who does not participate is treated as having given up, as deficient, or as in denial.

1.3 What Options Amatonormativity Removes

Concretely, Amatonormativity removes the option of chosen family without romantic pair. The friend who has been your primary support for twenty years cannot make medical decisions for you when you are incapacitated. The blood relative you have not seen in fifteen years can. The law recognises the romantic pair, not the chosen family.

It removes the option of platonic life partnership — the practice of building a life with a friend without romantic or sexual dimension. The platonic life partnership has no legal recognition, no social template, no cultural script. The two friends who buy a house together, raise children together, and grow old together are treated as eccentric rather than as a legitimate family form.

It removes the option of solo living without social cost. The person who chooses to live alone is treated as 'selfish,' 'lonely,' or 'not yet settled.' The solo life is treated as a deficit rather than a choice. It removes the option of polyamory, relationship anarchy, the aromantic life, the voluntary single life, and the celibate life. Each is treated as deviation from the couple-form norm.

It removes the option of non-romantic primary relationships — the practice of designating a friendship, a sibling bond, or a community connection as one's primary relationship, above and beyond any romantic pair. The non-romantic primary relationship has no social recognition, no legal protection, and no cultural script. Each removal is enforced by law, by family, by religion, and by the triads below.

SECTION 2 · NAIVE APPROACH

2. The Interpersonal Domain

The Interpersonal Domain contains four enforcement triads and four extraction triads. Each is described here as if happening for the first time — no networks, no residues, no Canon. Just the act, the conforming subject, the complicit witness, and (for extraction triads) the Non-Extracting Beneficiary.

3.1 Enforcement Triad: Couple-Form as Highest Relationship Standard

The enforcer is the person who demands recognition of the romantic partnership as the primary relationship. The parent who demands the adult child find a partner. The friend who treats the coupled friend's relationship as more important than the friendship. The employer who asks about the spouse but not the friend. The institution that requires the spouse's signature but not the friend's. The enforcement is performed by direct demand, by social priority, by institutional design, or by legal requirement.

The subject conforms by treating the romantic partnership as primary. The conforming act is the priority itself — the subject puts the partner above the friend, the family of origin, and the community. The single subject is the subject who has no partner to prioritise and is therefore treated as deficient.

The options the subject loses are concrete. The single person who has invested in friendship as their primary relationship loses the option to legal recognition of that friendship, which is to say, loses the option to medical decision-making, to inheritance, to immigration, to tax benefits. The coupled person who would rather maintain independent friendships loses the option to social approval, because the couple is expected to merge social circles.

The witness is the person who watches the couple-priority enforcement and says nothing, or who themselves prioritise their own couple and so model compliance. The Non-Extracting Beneficiary is the coupled friend who benefits from the single friend's deference without personally commanding it.

3.2 Enforcement Triad: Single as Temporary Standard

The enforcer is the person who treats the single state as transitional. The aunt who asks 'when are you getting married?' at every family event. The friend who says 'you'll find someone.' The colleague who assumes the single is looking. The parent who treats the single as not yet arrived at adulthood. The enforcement is performed by the question, by the reassurance, by the assumption, or by the social treatment.

The subject conforms by explaining, by justifying, by performing the search, or by hiding the contentment. The conforming act is the explanation itself — the single person produces a reason for

their single status, as if single status requires a reason.

The options the subject loses are concrete. The single person who is content loses the option to contentment without justification, which is to say, loses the option to a self that is not defined by the absence of a partner. The single person who is not looking loses the option to not-looking without social cost, which is to say, loses the option to a life that is not treated as a waiting room.

The witness is the person who watches the single-as-temporary enforcement and says nothing, or who themselves treat the single as temporary. The Non-Extracting Beneficiary is the coupled person who benefits from the single's perceived deficiency without personally commanding it.

3.3 Enforcement Triad: Aromantic as Broken Standard

The enforcer is the person who treats the aromantic as deficient. The friend who says 'you just haven't met the right person.' The family member who treats the aromantic as in need of repair. The therapist who treats the aromantic as having an attachment disorder. The media that has no representation of the aromantic. The enforcement is performed by the dismissal, by the diagnosis, by the erasure, or by the explicit correction.

The subject conforms by performing romantic interest, by hiding their aromanticism, by seeking 'repair,' or by entering relationships they do not want. The conforming act is the performance itself — the aromantic person performs romantic attraction to avoid the social cost of not performing it.

The options the subject loses are concrete. The aromantic person who is forced to perform romantic interest loses the option to self-acceptance, which is to say, loses the option to a self that is not defined by the absence of romantic attraction. The aromantic person who enters a relationship they do not want loses the option to bodily autonomy, to emotional autonomy, and to a life that is not built on a lie.

The witness is the person who watches the aromantic-as-broken enforcement and says nothing, or who themselves treat the aromantic as broken. The Non-Extracting Beneficiary is the coupled person who benefits from the aromantic's perceived deficiency without personally commanding it.

3.4 Enforcement Triad: Dating Culture as Mandatory Standard

The enforcer is the person or institution that demands the single person participate in the dating culture. The friend who sets up the single without asking. The family member who recommends the dating app. The media that treats dating as the default route to partnership. The social media that treats the relationship status as public identity. The enforcement is performed by the setup, by the recommendation, by the media framing, or by the social media default.

The subject conforms by dating, by being on the app, by accepting the setup, or by explaining why they are not dating. The conforming act is the participation itself — the single person is on the app, goes on the date, performs the dating script, regardless of whether they want to.

The options the subject loses are concrete. The single person who would rather not date loses the option to non-dating without social cost, which is to say, loses the option to a social life that does not

assume dating as the default activity. The single person who is on the app to avoid social cost loses the option to time, to emotional energy, and to self-esteem, because the dating app is designed to extract all three.

The witness is the person who watches the dating-culture enforcement and says nothing, or who themselves participate in the dating culture and so model compliance. The Non-Extracting Beneficiary is the dating app company that profits from the single's participation without personally commanding the mandatory standard.

3.5 Extraction Triad: Single Person's Deference

The extractor is the coupled person who requires the single person's deference. The coupled friend who expects the single friend to accommodate the couple's schedule. The coupled family member who expects the single to attend the couple's events. The coupled colleague who expects the single to work the holiday shift because the coupled person has family obligations. The extraction is performed by expectation, by guilt, or by social pressure.

The subject conforms by deferring. What is extracted is the deference itself — the labour of accommodating the couple's needs above the single's own. The extraction is invisible because it is performed as friendship or family obligation.

The options the subject loses are concrete. The single friend who always accommodates the couple loses the option to their own schedule, which is to say, loses the option to a life that is not organised around the couple's convenience. The single colleague who always works the holiday loses the option to rest, which is to say, loses the option to bodily recovery.

The witness is the person who watches the deference extraction and does not intervene, or who themselves extract deference from their own single friends. The Non-Extracting Beneficiary is the couple's children who benefit from the single's babysitting without personally commanding the deference.

3.6 Extraction Triad: Single Person's Stability

The extractor is the institution that requires the single person pay the 'singles tax.' The travel industry that charges the single supplement. The housing market that requires the single to afford the full rent. The tax system that denies the single the married person's allowance. The insurance system that charges the single more per person. The extraction is performed by the pricing, by the policy, by the tax code, or by the market.

The subject conforms by paying. What is extracted is the money itself — the extra cost of being single in a couple-default economy. The extraction is invisible because it is performed as market pricing.

The options the subject loses are concrete. The single person who pays the single supplement loses the option to travel at the same per-person cost as the coupled, which is to say, loses the option to equal economic treatment. The single person who pays the full rent loses the option to savings, which is to

say, loses the option to economic security.

The witness is the person who watches the stability extraction and does not intervene. The Non-Extracting Beneficiary is the coupled person who benefits from the couple-default pricing without personally commanding the extraction.

3.7 Extraction Triad: Aromantic Person's Self-Acceptance

The extractor is the culture that requires the aromantic person doubt their own orientation. The friend who says 'you just haven't met the right person.' The therapist who treats the aromantic as having an attachment disorder. The media that has no aromantic representation. The family that treats the aromantic as not-yet-arrived. The extraction is performed by the dismissal, by the diagnosis, by the erasure, or by the correction.

The subject conforms by doubting. What is extracted is the self-acceptance itself — the aromantic person's confidence in their own orientation, their own experience, their own identity. The extraction transfers the self-acceptance to the amatonormative standard, with the aromantic person left to wonder if they are broken.

The options the subject loses are concrete. The aromantic person who is told 'you just haven't met the right person' loses the option to self-knowledge, which is to say, loses the option to a self that is trusted. The aromantic person who is treated as broken loses the option to self-acceptance, which is to say, loses the option to a life that is not spent questioning their own orientation.

The witness is the person who watches the self-acceptance extraction and does not intervene. The Non-Extracting Beneficiary is the coupled person who benefits from the aromantic's perceived deficiency without personally commanding the extraction.

3.8 Extraction Triad: Non-Coupled Person's Social Standing

The extractor is the social system that requires the non-coupled person justify their non-coupled status. The family event that treats the single as the odd one out. The social gathering that treats the single as the third wheel. The professional network that treats the single as not yet settled. The religious community that treats the single as not yet complete. The extraction is performed by the seating arrangement, by the invitation language, by the social treatment, or by the explicit question.

The subject conforms by accepting the reduced standing. What is extracted is the social standing itself — the respect, the inclusion, the recognition that the coupled person receives by default. The extraction transfers the standing to the coupled, with the non-coupled left to justify their presence.

The options the subject loses are concrete. The single person who is treated as the odd one out at the family event loses the option to full participation, which is to say, loses the option to belonging. The single person who is treated as not yet settled in the professional network loses the option to professional respect, which is to say, loses the option to being taken seriously as an adult.

The witness is the person who watches the standing extraction and does not intervene. The Non-Extracting Beneficiary is the coupled person who benefits from the couple-default social standing without personally commanding the extraction.

Nascent forms of this system include: ‘When are you getting married?’, ‘When are you getting a boyfriend/girlfriend?’, ‘You’ll find someone’, ‘There’s someone for everyone’, ‘Don’t give up on love’, ‘Your biological clock is ticking’, ‘You’re too picky’, ‘You’re too independent’, ‘No man/woman is an island’, ‘The one’, ‘You complete me’, ‘Single and searching’, ‘Single and ready to mingle’, ‘Table for two?’, ‘Plus one?’, ‘Date night’, Valentine’s Day as couple’s holiday, The wedding as life milestone, The proposal as social media event, The engagement ring as social proof, The single aunt at the wedding, The ‘third wheel’, The ‘wingman’, The matchmaker, The dating app as mandatory infrastructure, The relationship status on Facebook, The couple’s joint Instagram, The single supplement (more expensive for singles), ‘You need to settle down’, ‘You’re not getting any younger’, ‘You don’t want to die alone’, ‘It is not good for man to be alone’.

SECTION 3 · NAIVE APPROACH

3. The Disciplinary Domain

When the eight triads above link into networks, Amatonormativity scales. The link can be hierarchical (the enforcer at one level is the subject at the level above) or community-based (the witness at one triad becomes the enforcer at another). Both forms are visible in every Nigerian institution that organises social life.

4.1 Disciplinary Hierarchy — Nested Stars

A Disciplinary Hierarchy is a chain of nested triads. The enforcer at one level is the subject at the level above. Each middle position is simultaneously subject above and enforcer below.

Amatonormativity spreads through this form in every Nigerian institution that organises couple-normativity.

Peak Triad-Node

At the peak is the triad where the highest couple-normative authority enforces on the layer below. In the wedding industrial complex, the peak is the wedding planner who enforces on the couple, who enforce on the bridal party, who enforce on the single guest. In the religious hierarchy, the peak is the pastor who demands marriage, who enforces on the married couple, who enforce on the engaged, who enforce on the single congregant. In the family hierarchy, the peak is the married elder who enforces on the married adult, who enforces on the engaged adult, who enforces on the single adult.

Middle Triad-Nodes

The middle nodes are where the chain's character is clearest. The married couple who were enforced on by the elder in the morning enforce on the single cousin in the afternoon. The engaged couple who were enforced on by the married friend in the morning enforce on the single colleague in the afternoon. The middle is where Amatonormativity reproduces — the subject of today is the enforcer of tomorrow, as the recently married person begins asking their single friends when they will marry.

Bottom Triad-Node

At the bottom is the triad where the lowest-ranked couple-normative enforcer enforces on the most vulnerable non-coupled person. The recently married friend enforcing on the long-term single. The engaged cousin enforcing on the aromantic sibling. The family member enforcing on the elderly single aunt. The bottom is where the system's violence is most concentrated — the single who has been asked 'when are you getting married?' so many times that the question has become a physical sensation.

4.2 Disciplinary Community — Distributed Network

A Disciplinary Community is a distributed network. There is no peak, no chain of command. There is only circulation. The witness of one Amatonormativity triad becomes the enforcer, subject, or witness

of another. Amatonormativity spreads laterally through any person who has witnessed couple-form enforcement without dissenting.

The Matchmaking Networks

The matchmaking networks circulate Amatonormativity laterally across the Nigerian family and social network. The aunt who recommends a potential partner. The friend who sets up the blind date. The colleague who suggests the dating app. The networks reproduce the dating-culture-as-mandatory triad across the social network, with no central command issuing the demand.

The Wedding Culture Networks

The wedding culture networks circulate Amatonormativity laterally through the spectacle of the wedding. The Instagram wedding photos. The WhatsApp wedding invitation. The aso-ebi (the matching fabric that marks the wedding party). The networks reproduce the couple-form-as-highest-relationship triad across the social network, with the wedding as the visible proof of the couple-form's supremacy.

The Family Pressure Networks

The family pressure networks circulate Amatonormativity laterally across the Nigerian family. The mother who asks 'when are you getting married?' The father who asks 'when am I meeting your partner?' The sibling who asks 'are you seeing anyone?' The networks reproduce the single-as-temporary triad across the household, with the family event as the primary enforcement site.

The Religious Marriage Networks

The religious marriage networks circulate Amatonormativity laterally across the Nigerian religious community. The marriage seminar. The couples' fellowship. The youth group's dating advice. The networks reproduce the couple-form-as-highest-relationship triad across the religious community, with the marriage framed as divine requirement (overlapping with Religious Dominance, Chapter 6).

The Social Media Couple Culture Networks

The social media couple culture networks circulate Amatonormativity laterally across the Nigerian digital public. The couple's joint Instagram. The wedding hashtags. The anniversary posts. The Valentine's Day tributes. The networks reproduce the couple-form-as-highest-relationship triad across the digital public, with the couple as the visible, celebrated, and default identity.

SECTION 4 · NAIVE APPROACH

4. The Structural Domain

Run the Ship of Theseus test. When the original matchmakers and original wedding planners are dead and replaced, when the networks are disbanded and reform, what is consistent? What outlives both individuals and groups? What forces new Nigerians to re-form into the same patterns — not because anyone instructs them to, but because the residue makes any other pattern costly or invisible?

Amatonormativity produces **Bureaucracy** and **Classification** but **not Stratification**. The framework's outline is explicit: Amatonormativity is ascended but does not produce stratification, because being single or coupled is not a zero-sum ranking in the way that owner/tenant or employed/unemployed is. The single person is not structurally below the coupled person in the material sense, though they are socially treated as deficient. Internalised Domination is therefore omitted from the Hegemonic Domain.

5.1 Bureaucracy — Enduring Rules and Procedures

Amatonormativity's bureaucracy is the codified couple-default structure. The Marriage Act 1914 codifies marriage as the only legally recognised partnership, with rights and responsibilities that no other relationship form receives. The tax system benefits married couples through joint assessment and spousal allowances. The immigration system recognises spousal visas but not platonic partnerships.

The housing system favours couples through joint tenancy, family rates, and the assumption that the household is a couple household. The insurance system favours couples through joint policies and spousal benefits. The hospital visitation system recognises spouses but not platonic partners — the friend who has been the primary support for twenty years cannot visit in intensive care; the spouse who was married yesterday can. The pension system recognises surviving spouses but not platonic partners.

The social registry defaults to 'married' as the adult status. The NYSC dependency rule recognises married women's posting with husbands but not platonic partnerships (overlapping with Cisheteropatriarchy, Chapter 5). The wedding industry is an economic bureaucracy — the wedding planners, the caterers, the photographers, the *aso-ebi* vendors, the venue owners — each extracting money from the couple-form performance. The dating app industry is another economic bureaucracy, extracting subscription fees from the single's search. The original 1914 Act authors are dead. The bureaucracy lives.

5.2 Classification — Enduring Categorical Divisions

Amatonormativity's classification is the set of categorical names that organise every Nigerian into couple-status categories. **Coupled** and **single** — the universal pair, with coupled as the default and single as the deviation. **Married** and **unmarried** — the legal pair, with married as the legitimate and unmarried as the temporary.

Romantic and **platonic** — the relationship-type pair, with romantic as the primary and platonic as the secondary. **Partnered** and **unpartnered** — the same pair in different language. **Complete** and **incomplete** — the moral pair, with coupled as complete and single as incomplete.

Settled and **unsettled** — the adulthood pair, with coupled as settled and single as unsettled. **Serious** and **casual** — the commitment pair, with the serious relationship as the goal and the casual as the waiting room. The classification does the work before any individual enforcer shows up. A single person walking into a Nigerian social event is already classified; the host does not need to ask 'are you seeing anyone?' because the category 'single' already carries the deficiency.

SECTION 5

5. The Hegemonic Domain: The Ascension Ritual

Is Amatonormativity ascended? Yes on all three counts. It produces structural residues (Bureaucracy and Classification, though not Stratification). It has working Canon and Practice mechanisms. The vast majority of Nigerians cannot imagine a society where the couple-form is not the default, where the single is not treated as temporary, where the aromantic is not treated as broken — despite the fact that the romantic couple-form is a recent historical invention.

A note on Internalised Domination. The framework's outline is explicit: Amatonormativity, although ascended, does not produce stratification. Therefore Internalised Domination is omitted entirely from this section. Only Internalised Authority and Internalised Oppression are described.

6.1 Canon — Rewriting History

Canon is the present belief that the couple-form has always been so. The origination of the structural residues — the Marriage Act 1914, the wedding industry, the dating culture — has been forgotten. The average Nigerian now takes the romantic couple-form as natural, eternal, and without alternative.

What is forgotten? The romantic couple-form is a recent historical invention. The romantic marriage — the marriage based on romantic love rather than economic or lineage arrangement — is an 18th-century European development, not an eternal human institution. Stephanie Coontz's *Marriage, A History* (2005) documented the shift. Pre-colonial Nigerian marriages were primarily economic and lineage arrangements, not romantic partnerships. The romantic ideal was imported through colonial education, colonial media, and colonial religion.

Also forgotten: that the 'soulmate' concept is a Western Romantic import, not an indigenous Nigerian concept. That the dating culture is a 20th-century American import, not an eternal human practice. That the wedding industry is a 20th-century commercial invention, not an ancient tradition — the elaborate Nigerian wedding with the white dress, the cake, the ring, and the photographer is a colonial and post-colonial adoption, not an indigenous practice.

Also forgotten: that pre-colonial Nigerian societies recognised multiple forms of partnership beyond the romantic couple. The Igbo female husband (documented by Amadiume, Chapter 4). The Yoruba polygynous household. The extended family as the primary social unit, not the nuclear couple. The colonial encounter imposed the monogamous romantic couple as the only legitimate form, and the Canon now presents it as natural.

Internalised Authority

Canon produces Internalised Authority in the amatonormative enforcer regardless of personal material gain. The right to ask ‘when are you getting married?’ The right to treat the single as deficient. The right to recommend dating apps. The right to pity the uncoupled. Each is performed by ordinary Nigerians daily — the aunt at the family event, the friend at the social gathering, the colleague at the office, the pastor at the church. The right to enforce feels natural, automatic, and legitimate.

The mother who asks ‘when are you getting married?’ gains nothing material from the answer. The friend who sets up the blind date gains nothing material from the setup. The pastor who preaches on marriage gains nothing material from each individual sermon. The married colleague who comments on the single’s social life gains nothing material. Each is exercising internalised authority — the felt right to enforce the couple-form standard regardless of personal gain.

Internalised Oppression

Canon produces Internalised Oppression in the single subject, the aromantic subject, and the non-coupled subject. The single person who believes they are incomplete. The aromantic person who believes they are broken. The non-coupled person who believes they are failing at life. The teaching is silent; it is in the air.

The single person who is told ‘you’ll find someone’ is being disciplined by Canon. The aromantic person who is told ‘you just haven’t met the right person’ is being disciplined by Canon. The non-coupled person who is told ‘you need to settle down’ is being disciplined by Canon. Each internalises the impossibility of refusal — the single person cannot refuse the search, the aromantic cannot refuse the performance, the non-coupled cannot refuse the justification.

The deepest form of this is the subject who has absorbed Amatonormativity so thoroughly that they enforce it on themselves. The single person who says ‘I should be dating’ to explain why they are on the app they do not want to be on. The aromantic person who says ‘something is wrong with me’ to explain why they do not feel romantic attraction. The non-coupled person who says ‘I am behind’ to explain why they feel like a failure. The rebellion-capable subject has become the self-policing subject.

6.2 Practice — Rewriting Reality

Practice is the second mechanism of the Ascension Ritual. The interpersonal triad is repeated, again and again, until it becomes habit. The amatonormative enforcer forgets they can choose not to enforce. The single subject forgets they can rebel. The witness forgets they can dissent. Pierre Bourdieu called this *habitus* — the sediment of repeated practice in the body.

Lauren Berlant, in *Cruel Optimism* (2011), showed how the attachment to the couple-form fantasy produces suffering rather than fulfilment. The subject who has internalised the couple-form as the route to the good life continues to pursue it even when it produces misery. The body learns. The mind stops questioning. By adulthood, the Nigerian has performed the couple-form-as-highest-relationship, single-as-temporary, aromantic-as-broken, and dating-culture-as-mandatory triads so many thousands of times that the alternative — chosen family, platonic life partnership, solo living, polyamory, the

aromantic life — feels like a kind of amputation. The body has been trained. Practice has rewritten reality.

Death — Fast and Slow

Practice produces Death. Fast death in Amatonormativity is spectacular: the suicide of the person who has been told ‘you will die alone’ so many times they believe it. The death in the pursuit of the couple-form — the dangerous cosmetic procedure for the dating profile, the dangerous weight loss for the wedding, the death from the abusive relationship the subject entered because being coupled was treated as better than being single, even when the coupling was violent.

Slow death in Amatonormativity is quiet. Chronic stress of being single in a coupled-default world — the single person who has not slept properly in years because every social event requires the performance of contentment, every family gathering requires the justification of singlehood, every professional encounter requires the explanation of the missing ring. Mental health collapse from internalised incompleteness — the single person who has internalised the ‘incomplete’ label so deeply that their body breaks down under the weight.

The slow erosion of platonic friendships as the coupled withdraw into the couple — the friend who was your primary support for twenty years and who, upon marrying, disappears into the couple, leaving you with the social network that was built around a friendship that no longer exists in the same form. The slow death of the single person’s social network as friends pair off — the gradual realisation that the social world has reorganised itself around couples, and the single is no longer the default guest but the odd one out.

The cumulative damage of the dating culture on self-esteem — the dating app that is designed to produce rejection, the date that does not call back, the relationship that ends without explanation, each eroding the self. The financial drain of the dating and wedding economy — the subscription fees, the date costs, the wedding costs, the aso-ebi costs, the travel costs. The aromantic person’s chronic alienation from a world that assumes everyone experiences romantic attraction — the person who cannot understand why everyone is so obsessed with dating, who cannot explain why they are not, and who is told there is something wrong with them. None of these make the news. They are Amatonormativity’s quiet tax.

Ruth Wilson Gilmore’s definition applies with a modification: Amatonormativity produces group-differentiated vulnerability to premature death, though not through stratification (which Amatonormativity does not produce) but through the social and psychological damage of compulsory couple-form enforcement. The groups are the single, the aromantic, the non-coupled, the platonic life partner, the polyamorous person, the person in the abusive relationship entered because coupling was mandatory. The premature death is fast (suicide, abusive-relationship death, cosmetic-procedure death) or slow (stress, mental health collapse, friendship erosion, network collapse, self-esteem damage, financial drain, aromantic alienation). Every ascended matrix kills. Amatonormativity kills those whose relational form does not fit the couple-form model.

SECTION 6

6. When Did Amatonormativity Rewrite History?

The framework's historical question: when did Amatonormativity rewrite history in popular Nigerian living memory, such that the average Nigerian cannot recall a time when its structural residue was not present? This is not a history of how Amatonormativity was built. It is a diagnosis of when the building was forgotten.

Pre-colonial Nigerian partnerships were more diverse. Marriages were primarily economic and lineage arrangements, not romantic partnerships. The Igbo female husband. The Yoruba polygynous household. The extended family as the primary social unit, not the nuclear couple. The romantic ideal was not the organising principle of partnership; the lineage was. The single person was not treated as deficient; the person who had not married was treated as not-yet-aligned with the lineage's reproductive strategy, but not as personally incomplete.

Colonial codification imposed the romantic couple-form. The Marriage Act 1914 codified the monogamous Christian marriage as the only legally recognised partnership. The colonial school introduced the romantic ideal through the curriculum and the missionary teaching. The colonial media introduced the romantic couple through literature and cinema. The colonial church introduced the theological frame that made the couple-form divine. Each was a political decision, not a natural development.

Post-independence replication continued the displacement. Nigerian law retained the Marriage Act. Nigerian media retained the romantic ideal, with Nollywood intensifying it from the 1990s. Nigerian religion retained the theological frame, with Pentecostalism intensifying it from the 1970s. The dating app arrived in the 2010s, intensifying the dating culture. The wedding industry expanded exponentially from the 2000s, intensifying the wedding as life milestone.

The tipping point in popular living memory: **circa 1914 for the Marriage Act** that codified the couple-form as the only legally recognised partnership; **circa 1960s-1970s for the consolidation of Western romantic ideology** through Nollywood and popular culture; **circa 2000s-2010s for the dating app and wedding industry intensification**. For Nigerians born after 1960, Amatonormativity has 'always been' in its current form. They cannot recall a time when the couple-form was not the default, when the single was not treated as temporary, when the aromantic was not treated as broken.

SECTION 7

7. Fill in the Blank: A Self-Examination

The framework asks two questions of every subject of every ascended matrix. The blanks are for you. They are not rhetorical. The point of the framework is not to understand Amatonormativity in the abstract. It is to locate yourself inside it, so that the next time the triad assembles around you — or around someone whose relational form does not fit the couple-form model — you can see it.

Question 1: When did Amatonormativity rewrite your reality?

When did the system teach you that you could not rebel? The moment was: _____. The year was: _____. The person who first made you feel that challenging the couple-form was impossible was: _____. The place was: _____. What you wanted to say but did not was: _____. What you did instead was: _____. What you told yourself about why you did not say it was: _____. The couple-form performance you assumed in that moment was: _____. The form of address you used was: _____. What you lost, in that moment, that you have not got back since, was: _____. The enforcement form at the centre of the moment (couple-priority, single-as-temporary, aromantic-as-broken, dating-culture-mandatory) was: _____.

Question 2: How is Amatonormativity causing your Death?

How is the system shortening your life right now? The form of Death I am most afraid of from Amatonormativity is (fast/slow): _____. The specific way it is happening in my body is: _____. (For example: the chronic stress from years of being asked when I am getting married; the insomnia from years of performing contentment as a single person; the loss of self from years of being told I am incomplete; the breakdown I had in 20__ that I have never fully recovered from; the friendship I lost because the friend disappeared into the couple; the social network that collapsed as friends paired off; the dating app that eroded my self-esteem; the wedding costs that drained my savings; the relationship I entered because being coupled was mandatory even though I did not want it; the aromantic alienation from a world that assumes everyone experiences romantic attraction.) The matrix's name for what is happening to me is: _____. My own name for it is: _____.

If you filled in the blanks honestly, you have just located yourself inside Amatonormativity. The next time the triad assembles — the next time the question ‘when are you getting married?’ is asked, the next time the single is treated as temporary, the next time the aromantic is treated as broken, the next time the dating app is recommended — you will be able to see the system moving through you. That sight is the beginning of abolition. And if you are now the enforcer in the triad — the aunt, the friend, the colleague, the pastor — the sight is also the beginning of your refusal to enforce.

SECTION 8

8. Endnotes & References

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Coming Next

Chapter 15 will take up Compulsory Existence / Suicidism — the system that enforces existence on those who would rather not exist, criminalises the attempt to leave, and removes the option of a self-determined end. The framework’s outline names it as the system that makes suicide illegal, that treats the suicide attempt survivor as criminal rather than patient, and that enforces the ‘sanctity of life’ as a non-negotiable standard. Compulsory Existence overlaps with Retributivism (Chapter 13, which criminalises the suicide attempt) and with Sanism (Chapter 12, which treats the suicidal mind as mad). The framework separates them so that the compulsory-existence logic specifically can be studied and dismantled.

If you are reading this chapter as part of the framework in progress, the order continues: Chapter 16 is Meritism / The Significant, Chapter 17 is Ethnic Majoritarianism, Chapter 18 is Territorialism, and so on through the Fundamental Matrices. Each chapter follows the same template established in Chapters 2 through 14. The naive approach in the first three domains (or its waiver, as in Chapter 11). The Ascension Ritual in the fourth (with Internalised Domination omitted when the matrix does not produce stratification, as in this chapter). The historical memory trace. The fill-in-the-blank. The endnotes. The pattern is now set.